

EVIDENCE GATHERING GUIDE

For: John Doe

Evidence is everything in eviction court. The right evidence can win your case. This guide tells you what to gather and how to organize it.

1. WRITTEN EVIDENCE — MOST IMPORTANT

- Your LEASE or rental agreement — bring the entire document.
- All RENT RECEIPTS, bank statements, canceled checks, money order stubs.
- All notices from the landlord — pay or quit notice, eviction notice, ANY letter.
- All text messages and emails with your landlord — print them out.
- Any repair requests you sent — texts, emails, certified letters, work orders.
- Any letters from code enforcement, health department, or housing inspectors.
- Your eviction summons and complaint — bring ALL pages.

2. PHOTOS & VIDEO

- Take photos of EVERY repair issue — broken appliances, leaks, mold, pests, damage.
- Date each photo. Use a newspaper in the photo to prove the date if needed.
- Take photos of the ENTIRE unit — show overall condition.
- If safe, take photos of the outside — building condition, trash, hazards.
- Video walkthrough: Narrate as you film. 'Today is [date]. This is the leaking ceiling...'

3. WITNESSES

- Neighbors who saw or heard problems — ask them to come to court or write a statement.
- Other tenants in your building facing similar issues — compare notes.
- Anyone who was present when your landlord said or did something relevant.
- Witness statement format: name, address, phone, date, what they saw/heard, signature.

4. ORGANIZATION — CRITICAL

- Put everything in chronological order — oldest first.
- Create a simple TIMELINE: Date → What happened → Evidence you have.
- Use a 3-ring binder or folder with tabs for each category.
- Make 3 copies of EVERYTHING — one for the judge, one for the landlord, one for you.
- Write a brief SUMMARY (1 page max) of your case — key dates and facts.

DO NOT bring original documents to court unless you have copies. The court keeps what you file — do NOT give away your only copy of anything.